Desert Fathers Wisdom

A discussion game for adults — Ages 18+ — 3-8 Players — 30 Minutes

Age Range	Players	Play Time	Difficulty
18+	**3-8**	**30 minutes**	**Easy**

About This Game

The desert fathers and mothers are the spiritual ancestors of the Coptic Church. Their sayings — brief, often paradoxical, always penetrating — have guided souls toward God for seventeen centuries. Desert Fathers Wisdom brings these sayings to the table for honest, shared reflection.

> **Formation Goal:** Cultivating humility, self-awareness, and watchfulness — the core of the desert tradition.

Components

- **40 Saying Cards** — each containing a saying with attribution
- **Rules** (this sheet)
- **Leader Guide** — historical context and discussion prompts
- **Reflection Sheet** — for personal journaling after the session

Setup

1. Print the saying cards on cardstock and cut along borders.
2. Shuffle all 40 cards and place them face-down in a stack.
3. Sit in a circle. Choose one person to facilitate (or take turns).
4. Open with a brief prayer: "Lord, open our hearts to receive Your wisdom through the words of the fathers. Amen."

How to Play

1. The facilitator draws the top card and reads the saying aloud. **Read it slowly.**
2. **Pause in silence** for 15-30 seconds. Let the saying settle.
3. Going around the circle, each person shares a brief response. Suggested prompts:
   - "What strikes you about this saying?"
   - "What does this challenge in your own life?"
   - "What do you not understand about this saying?"
4. After everyone has shared, the facilitator may read the context from the **Leader Guide**.
5. Draw the next card. Continue for as many rounds as time allows (typically 5-8 sayings in 30 minutes).

Guidelines for Discussion

- **There are no points. There is no winner.** The conversation is the game.
- **Listen more than you speak.** The desert fathers valued silence.
- **Speak about yourself, not others.** "This challenges me because..." not "People should..."
- **It is fine to be confused.** Many sayings are paradoxical. Sit with the discomfort.
- **Do not argue.** Share perspectives, but do not debate. Receive what others say.

Closing

After the final saying, close with a moment of silence and a prayer. Distribute the **Reflection Sheet** for those who wish to continue processing privately.

Variants

- **Personal meditation:** Use the cards alone as daily meditation prompts. Draw one card per day.

- **Written response:** Instead of speaking, have each person write their response first, then share.
- **Themed session:** Sort cards by theme (humility, prayer, judgement, repentance) and use one theme per session.

> *"Remember those who rule over you, who have spoken the word of God to you, whose faith follow, considering the outcome of their conduct." — Hebrews 13:7*